



THIS IS HOW THE OIL IS STOLEN

Sharma has been arrested in six cases so far, Zuber Hussain Shaikh of Mehsana, who operates with two other accomplices, has been booked more than three times.

The modus operandi of oil thieves also vary. While in one case Bodio collected the oil in two large iron tanks buried in the earth, in another he installed Sintex containers in a truck for collecting the stolen oil. The thieves also steal oil from the oil well itself—a bolt is removed from the well to pump the oil into a tanker using a pipe. Last month, the Mehsana Police arrested a ceramic factory owner and his son with four of his employees for stealing crude oil in this manner. They used the oil in their factory.

monthly bribe to the police with the SP getting the major chunk of Rs 10 lakh. Desai, now suspended, has reportedly given a graphic account of how the whole racket is conducted right under the police nose. "Why I alone be punished when other much larger fish amongst the police officers are involved in the racket?" Desai, who lives in great style despite being suspended, told INDIA TODAY. Significantly, the names of officers taken by Bodio and those named by Desai have several in common. Says Minister of State for Home Amit Shah: "Come what may, we are keen to go to the bottom of this racket so that we curb it once and for all."

The racket raises serious questions. Drilling into an oil pipeline takes hours and this casts a shadow of doubt

Of the 85 cases of oil theft registered in Ahmedabad district, judgements have been delivered in just two, both being acquittals.

As many as 503 cases of theft of oil and fuel from ONGC and IOC pipelines have been registered in Gujarat since 2001, and nearly a dozen small and big gangs have been found to be involved in this activity. There has been no conviction in these cases so far. For example, in the 85 cases registered in Ahmedabad district since 2001, a chargesheet has been filed in 82 cases. Of these, judgement has come in just two cases, in both of which the accused have been acquitted.

The police officers that Bodio has named this time are not the first to be pointed fingers at. In an IOC pipeline theft case last year, a constable of Ahmedabad district police shocked one and all when he filed an affidavit naming over half a dozen police personnel, including an IC and SP, as beneficiaries of huge bribes of Gatio, who is second only to Bodio. Hemraj Desai filed the affidavit in self-defence after he was booked for complicity with Gatio. According to the affidavit, Gatio along with other oil thieves used to pay Rs 35 lakh as

over their patrolling by the oil firms. Police are tightlipped on the matter. Says A.K. Hazarika, director, onshore operations, ONGC: "We won't deny that some of our own staff members might also be involved in the oil thefts. What is needed is a combined effort to end this racket. We are determined to root it out." Recently, ONGC rewarded some policemen for detecting theft. The ONGC staff alone detected 18 cases during the past one year. ONGC has around 12,000 km of pipelines in Gujarat. According to Anil Johri, executive director at ONGC's Ahmedabad unit, it is not so easy to guard the entire pipeline network round the clock despite the fact they have security personnel from four agencies. Says Shah: "The law needs to be amended to ensure stringent punishment for oil theft which is nothing less than anti-national activity."

Anti-national or not, as long as police officials and oil company employees are willing to be bribed to look the other way, Gujarat's oil spill will continue to spread. ■

— Senior police officers have been accused of being beneficiaries of huge bribes from more than one gang of oil thieves.

— There is no special provision in the law that can be an effective deterrent to this activity.

— ONGC alone has around 12,000 km of pipelines in Gujarat.

Slippery Customer

Indravadan Patel alias Bodio whose gang has stolen crude oil and other fuels worth nearly Rs 300 crore from ONGC pipelines in the past five years is the biggest crude oil smuggler in Gujarat. He has been arrested at least five times for crude oil theft. Son of a wealthy farmer from Ahmedabad's outskirts, Bodio took to oil thievery because of the debts that he had incurred because of his habits of heavy drinking and womanising.